At its broadest level, this is visible in the manner in which the outcomes of 1945 are utilized to define an international hierarchy. The trick obviously is to imbue a particular moment with enormous significance and, thereafter, derive continuous benefit from it. Arguments to make the world more contemporary are rebutted by conflating them with challenging the original outcome in question. This, however, is but one example of the larger tussle to maintain or change the world as we know it today. There are many more, some limited in scope and others more sweeping. They help to create and maintain frameworks, operate and defend structures and, crucially, establish and advance narratives. And they succeed to a great degree because global behaviour is shaped so much by muscle memory. We are all not just creatures of habits but followers of norms and believers of storylines.

A combination of these factors conceals the vested interests that underpin the arrangements of the day. It could be the UN and its working, nuclear non-proliferation, the selective focus on human rights, the equally calculated balancing of realpolitik and values, as well as the utilization of Cold War imagery. Particular moments also serve to define the ‘other’ sharply, such as after the 9/11 attack. So does the evocation of past conflicts, especially the last World War. For all these reasons, attempts to reshape global debates and concepts meet with the fiercest resistance. That is something India must expect and counter.

As a rising power, India encounters freezing the moment in different formats. It can come up against institutions and practices that do not give it its due. That is why it is such a strong proponent of reformed multilateralism. It can shape its approach to other powers, sometimes to our detriment. This requires confident thinking to create more up-to-date terms of engagement. On occasion, impactful moments can lead to such strong perceptions that it puts pressure on policy to adjust. To a considerable degree, that is the case with Pakistan after the 26/11 Mumbai terror attack. The Indian public clearly saw the governmental response as weak-kneed and pushed for a change.

There could even be situations when we will want to move on rapidly beyond an action. That was certainly the case of the Vajpayee government in reaching out to key partners soon after the 1998 nuclear tests. It is sometimes the fate of nations to also inherit the concepts and assumptions of others. The global understanding of India’s place and influence is a relevant example, one very much shaped by other powers. It is only in